

Definition of Games and Play

The Magic Circle

Games

Are these Games?



- Consider these activities
 - Children playing with dolls
 - Jumping rope
 - Using a slot machine in Las Vegas
 - Driving
 - Playing Monopoly
 - Russian Roulette?

Kaba Kick: Russian roulette “for kids.” Instead of bullets, a pair of feet come out the barrel. If gun doesn’t fire, player earns points



Challenges in Creating Definitions of Games

- What are *unique qualities* that make a game a game?
 - How to differentiate games from play, conflict and simply rule-governed behavior
- Some *general qualities* of a game
 - Has **rules**
 - Has a **goal**
 - Involves **decision making**
 - Safe, **outside of ordinary life**
 - **Voluntary**
 - **Outcome is uncertain**
- Ideally, definitions of game should address these

Clark Abt definition

- In *Serious Games*, Clark C. Abt defines games as follows:

*Reduced to its formal essence, a game is an **activity** among two or more **independent decision-makers** seeking to achieve their **objectives** in some **limiting context**. A more conventional definition would say that a game is a context with rules among adversaries trying to win objectives.*

- **Key elements of Abt's definition**

- **Activity:** Game is a series of actions taking place over time
- **Decision-makers:** People playing the game are actively making decisions
- **Objectives:** There is a goal to the game, a desired outcome
- **Limiting context:** Rules exist that structure and limit the activity of the game

Abt Definition Applied

Reduced to its formal essence, a game is an activity among two or more **independent decision-makers** seeking to achieve their objectives in some **limiting context**.

How does this definition apply to the six activities from earlier this lecture?

- Children playing with dolls
- Jumping rope
- Using a slot machine in Las Vegas
- Russian roulette
- Playing Monopoly
- Driving

Which of these would Abt consider to be a game?

Exercise 3-1

- See *Canvas* for details

Costikyan Definition

Greg Costikyan defines games as follows:

*A game is a form of **art** in which **participants**, termed **players**, **make decisions** in order to **manage resources** through game tokens in **pursuit of a goal**.*

Key elements of Costikyan's definition

- **Art:** Games are a form of art, hence creating culture
- **Decision-making players:** Players actively participating and making choices
- **Resource management:** Decisions made depend on resources available, and manipulating resources
- **Game tokens:** Representation of the state of the game, affordances for user action
- **Goal:** Objective of the game

Costikyan Definition Applied

A game is a **form of art** in which participants, termed players, make **decisions** in order to **manage resources** through game tokens in pursuit of **a goal**.

How does this definition apply to the six activities from earlier this lecture?

- Children playing with dolls
- Jumping rope
- Using a slot machine in Las Vegas
- Russian roulette
- Playing Monopoly
- Driving

Which of these would Costikyan consider to be a game?

Exercise 3-2

- See *Canvas* for details

Jesper Juul's Classic Game Definition

From *Half-Real*, Jesper Juul, MIT Press, 2005, p. 36



jesperjuul.net

- **Rules:** Games are rule-based
- **Variable, quantifiable outcome:** Games have varying endings, with different numbers assignable to specific outcomes
- **Valorization of outcome:** The different potential outcomes of the game are assigned different values, some positive and some negative
- **Player effort:** The player exerts effort in order to influence the outcome
 - Games are challenging

Jesper Juul's Classic Game Definition

From *Half-Real*, Jesper Juul, MIT Press, 2005, p. 36



jesperjuul.net

- **Player attached to outcome:** The player is emotionally attached to the outcome of the game in the sense that a player will be a “winner” and happy in case of a positive outcome, but a loser and “unhappy” in case of a negative outcome.
- **Negotiable consequences:** The same game [set of rules] can be played with or without real-world consequences.
 - For example, poker: Can play this game without betting real money. Once money is bet, the game has real-world consequences.

Juul Definition Applied

Rules

Variable, quantifiable outcome

Valorization of outcome

Player effort

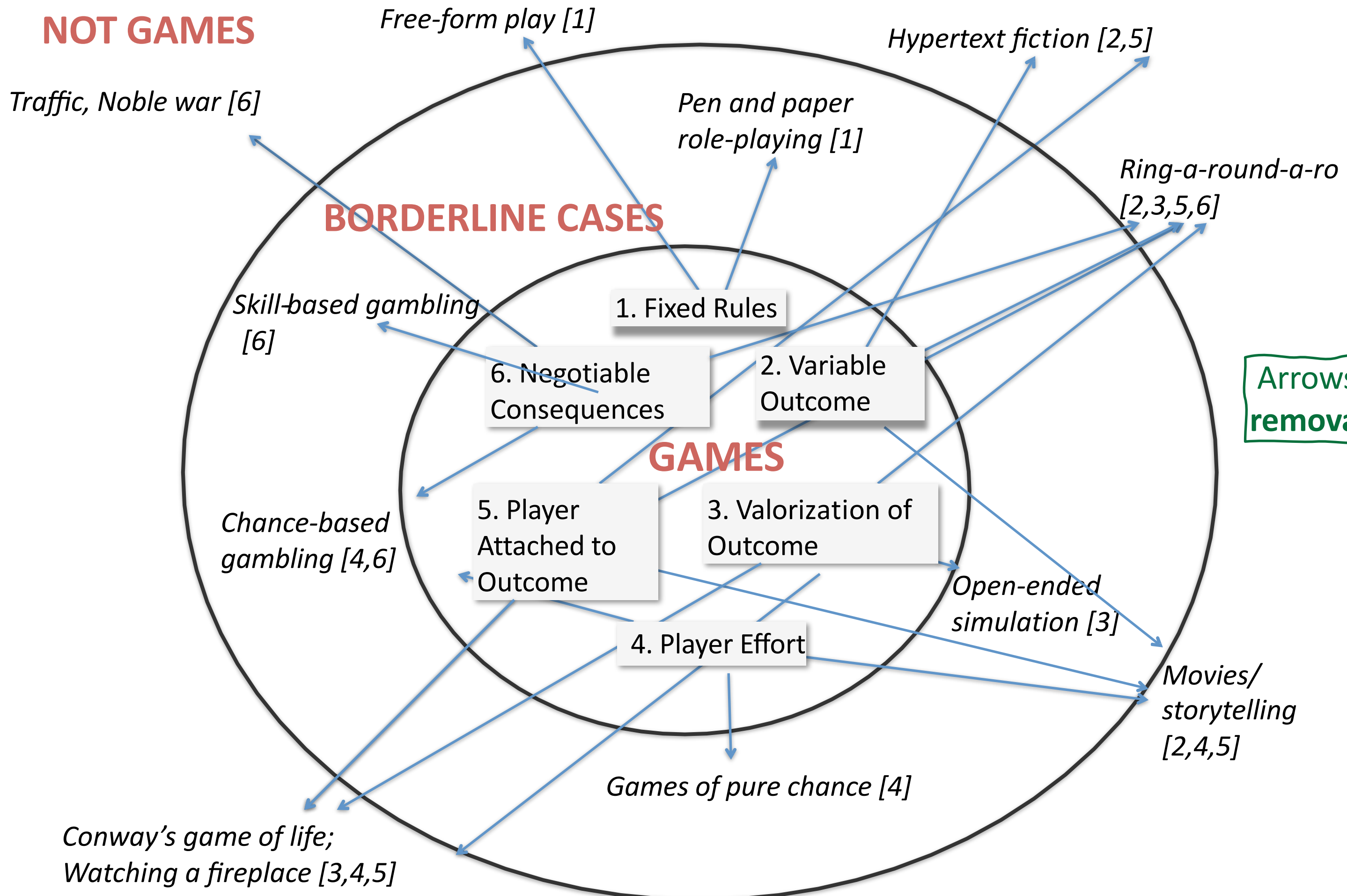
Player attached to outcome

Negotiable consequences

How does this definition apply to the six activities from earlier this lecture?

- Children playing with dolls
- Jumping rope
- Using a slot machine in Las Vegas
- Russian roulette
- Playing Monopoly
- Driving

Which of these would Juul consider to be a game?



This chart is based on Jesper Juul's definition of game.

Play and *The Magic Circle*

Play

Johann Huizinga's 1938 book *Homo Ludens* defines play as:

[Play is] a free activity standing quite consciously outside “ordinary” life as being “not serious,” but at the same time absorbing the player intensely and utterly. It is an activity connected with no material interest, and no profit can be gained by it. It proceeds within its own proper boundaries of time and space according to fixed rules and in an orderly manner. It promotes the formation of social groupings, which tend to surround themselves with secrecy and to stress their difference from the common world by disguise or other means.

- Does good job capturing essence of play “absorbing the player intensely and utterly”
- Does not well distinguish games and play
 - Children's play is not strongly rule based, but is definitely play
- Do games always create social groupings?

Roger Caillois' Definition of Play

From *Man, Play, and Games*, play is:

Free: Playing is **not obligatory**; if it were, it would at once lose its attractive and joyous quality as diversion

Separate: Circumscribed within limits of space and time, defined and fixed in advance

Uncertain: the course of which cannot be determined, nor the result attained beforehand, and some latitude for innovations being left to the player's initiative

Unproductive: Creating neither goods, nor wealth, nor new elements of any kind, and, except for the exchange of property among the players, ending in a situation identical to that prevailing at the beginning of the game.

Roger Caillois' Definition of Play (cont'd)

From *Man, Play, and Games*, play is:

Governed by Rules: Under conventions that suspend ordinary laws, and for the moment establish new legislation, which alone counts

Make-believe: Accompanied by a special awareness of a second reality or of a free unreality, as against real life

Roger Caillois' Definition of Play

Governed by Rules: Under conventions that suspend ordinary laws, and for the moment establish new legislation, which alone counts

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Good points

- Identifies play as being voluntary
- Captures importance of fictional element of play

Bad points

- Easy to think of counter-examples:
 - Professional sports players are not playing voluntarily (have signed a contract)
 - Some games are purely abstract, with no fictional aspect (Tic-Tac-Toe)
 - Children's play is not strongly rule based

The Magic Circle

- When children play games and call “time out!” what does this mean?
 - Gameplay **time** stops
 - Players go **out** of the game space
- Michael Apter writes: In the play-state you experience a protective frame which stands between you and the “real” world and its problems, creating an enchanted zone in which, in the end, you are confident that no harm can come.
- Game Studies researchers call this enchanted zone the ***magic circle***
 - Term originally comes from Huizinga’s *Homo Ludens*
 - Elegantly **captures the notion of the boundaries of a game**

Salen and Zimmerman on The Magic Circle

The fact that **the magic circle** is just that—a circle—is an important feature of this concept. As a closed circle, the space it circumscribes is enclosed and separate from the real world. As a marker of time, the magic circle is like a clock: it simultaneously represents a path with a beginning and end, but one without beginning and end. The magic circle inscribes a space that is repeatable, a space both limited and limitless. In short, a finite space with infinite possibility.

p. 95, *Rules of Play*



Magic Circle (1886) John William Waterhouse

The Magic Circle (cont'd)

- Idea introduced by **Johan Huizinga** in his book *Homo Ludens*.
- Describes the world that players enter when they choose to participate in a game.
 - Captures the idea of engaging in actions that normally would not be feasible or necessary, or that are out of the ordinary.
 - A boundary between the real world and the “reality” of the game.
 - Responsible for mechanisms that are unusual and/or unique to the game.
 - Provides a boundary or frame that defines the time and space of the game.
- Addresses the idea of immersion, i.e., drawing the player in.

Exercise 3-3

- See *Canvas* for details